

5.1 Layer Styles

A layer style, or more appropriately, a layer effect, is an effect applied in Photoshop to an entire layer—everything in that one layer. You can apply one or more various effects directly to a layer, such as giving it a drop shadow, embossing it, or even overlaying a layer with a colour or pattern to give it the depth that's required in order to make an image look realistic.

In order to get to the Layer Styles menu and select an effect, just right-click on the layer you want to change, and select Blending Options. You should now see the Layer Styles dialog box. From here you can use the various preset effects we will explain below.

5.1.1 Shadows

Drop Shadow

Mostly used with text, and when working with cut-outs, a drop shadow is meant to do away with the whole *Photoshopped* look of elements in your picture. Yes there's even a term called "Photoshopped," that's used by many design artists to describe when an image or element of an image does not look natural!

Tip

You can also use drop shadows if you want a certain coloured text to be easily visible on a background that does not offer very good contrast!

Basically, you can add a shadow to the contents of a layer, so as to add depth and also to match lighting sources of all elements in an image. The simplest example is text: we often want to give text a 3D look, and that's where drop shadows are important. In the images alongside, you will see that the first image has just plain text, while the second has the same text with a Drop Shadow effect applied to it. The difference is that the second is noticeably better!

In order to apply a drop shadow, just check the option in the Layer Style dialog box we told you about, play with the different settings and then click OK. Remember, trust only your eyes,